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Prepared By:	**Product Management Team**		

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Executive Summary

TeamUp is a project-collaboration platform designed to help digital skill learners and early-career professionals turn their knowledge into practical experience. It enables users to discover real projects, find suitable collaborators, agree on roles and commitments, work through tasks and milestones, and document individual contributions.

Research conducted with 48 respondents highlighted challenges including lack of commitment, poor communication, unclear responsibilities and abandoned team projects. Respondents also valued completed projects and supporting documentation as evidence of practical experience.

TeamUp keeps groups functional in three ways. Commitment is explicit before anyone joins: each person sees and accepts their role, weekly hours and deadlines. Progress is visible while the team builds: every task has an owner and a deadline, and overdue work is flagged to the whole team. When someone goes quiet, the team is prompted to follow up, and the owner can release the role and open it to a replacement. Because each person's confirmed contribution becomes part of their portfolio evidence, they also have a personal reason to stay active.

The MVP focuses on the core journey: discovering collaborators, forming teams, establishing clear commitments, completing project work and producing a record of individual contributions. Advanced matching, full in-app chat and other non-essential features will be considered after the core experience has been validated.

1. Product Overview

Product Name

TeamUp

One-Line Description

TeamUp is a project-collaboration platform that helps people turn what they have learned into practical experience by forming functional teams around real projects.

What TeamUP Does

Many people learn digital skills through courses, bootcamps and self-study, but struggle to find the right collaborators, a real project and enough structure to finish. TeamUp closes that gap. It lets users:

- Create a profile showing their skills, interests, goals and availability.
- Create a project or discover projects that need collaborators, with the roles and commitment clearly defined.
- Find collaborators with complementary skills and compatible availability.
- Review roles, time commitment and deadlines before joining a team.
- Work in a shared workspace with tasks, milestones, progress tracking and light accountability.
- Record each person's contribution and generate a project page they can use as portfolio evidence.

The TeamUp Core Loop

1 **LEARN** Gain a digital skill	**2** **FIND PEOPLE** Match on skills and availability	**3** **FORM TEAM** Agree roles and commitment	**4** **BUILD** Work in milestones
5 **COMPLETE** Ship the project	**6** **DOCUMENT** Record each contribution	**7** **SHOW EXPERIENCE** Share a project page	↻ **REPEAT** Start the next project

Product Vision

Anyone who learns a digital skill should be able to find the right team, build something real and leave with proof of what they personally contributed.

Product Positioning

For digital skill learners, fresh graduates, career switchers and early-career professionals who have skills but lack practical project experience, TeamUp is a project-collaboration platform that forms teams

around real projects and keeps them functional through completion. Unlike a networking site or a teammate directory, TeamUp is built around the full journey from team formation to completed project to evidence of contribution.

Initial beachhead: young African digital professionals and learners in product management, UI/UX design, software development, data and digital marketing who have basic skills and want collaborative project experience.

Competitor Analysis

The team-formation space is not empty. The table below compares the products that overlap with parts of the TeamUp journey. It is based on public product information and is not an exhaustive market study.

Product	Observed Focus	Overlap with TeamUp	Opportunity for TeamUp
Devpost	Hackathon discovery and team formation.	Users can find participants, send team-up requests and form hackathon teams.	Focus on ongoing, non-hackathon projects and the learning-to-experience progression.
CoFoundMe	Founder-builder matching for early-stage startups.	Matching uses skills, sectors, work style, hours, timezone and commitment; includes shared workspace and sprints.	Target skill learners and short-term project experience rather than co-founder formation.
PairUp	Co-founder and collaborator matching around ideas.	Users post ideas, define roles, match with contributors and start building.	Make practical learning and portfolio evidence the core outcome, not startup formation.

Product	Observed Focus	Overlap with TeamUp	Opportunity for TeamUp
ShipTogether	Network for finding people to build with.	Profiles emphasise shipped work; users connect with builders and post projects.	Serve people still building their first meaningful experience, not mainly existing builders.

TeamUp does not claim to have invented team matching. Its differentiator is the Project-to-Portfolio Engine: finishing a project produces structured evidence of what each person actually did. This is a product hypothesis, so execution of the full journey is what will set TeamUp apart.

Market Gap

Existing Pattern	Typical End Goal	TeamUp Opportunity
Professional networking	Connections and visibility	Project participation and experience
Hackathon team formation	A team for a time-boxed competition	A team for ongoing skill development
Co-founder matching	A long-term startup partner	Collaborators for defined learning and build projects
Builder networks	Connections around existing work	Help earlier-stage builders create their first or next meaningful work
Project tools	Manage an already-formed team	Help people find the team before execution begins

2. Problem Statement

Core Problem

Many people learn digital skills but struggle to turn that knowledge into practical experience because they lack the right collaborators, real projects, structure and accountability. As a result, they may have skills and certificates but limited evidence of what they can actually build.

Key Problem Areas

- ➢ Difficulty finding collaborators.
- ➢ Difficulty finding people with complementary skills.
- ➢ Difficulty finding people who are actually available.
- ➢ Teams become inactive after they form.
- ➢ Projects being abandoned before completion.
- ➢ Difficulty finding real projects that count as portfolio experience.

Research Evidence

- ❖ 50.0% of respondents (24 of 48) had experienced a team project being abandoned or never completed.
- ❖ Finding people with complementary skills (31.2%) and finding people who are available (29.2%) were the two biggest barriers to finding collaborators.
- ❖ Finding real projects to work on was the top portfolio challenge (58.3%), ahead of finding people to collaborate with (45.8%).
- ❖ The leading reasons teams become inactive were lack of commitment (62.5%), poor communication (56.2%) and loss of interest (52.1%).
- ❖ When a deadline is missed, teams mostly respond manually: 50.0% follow up with the person and 35.4% have someone else take over the task.

The main causes of failure are coordination and behavioural problems, not technical ones. A simple directory of skilled people would therefore not solve the problem.

3. Research Insights & Evidence

The survey describes a chain of connected problems rather than one pain point. The insights below follow that chain: finding people, forming teams, staying functional, completing projects and showing evidence.

Key Numbers at a Glance

50.0%	62.5%	72.9%	89.1%
had a team project abandoned or never completed	name lack of commitment as a top reason teams go inactive	value a completed project most as evidence of contribution	are likely or very likely to use TeamUp (41 of 46 who answered)

Source: TeamUp survey, 48 responses.

Finding People

- People already use informal channels: WhatsApp/Telegram groups and friends/classmates (56.2% each), then LinkedIn (37.5%).
- Working outside existing communities is not routine: 35.4% do it rarely and only 29.2% do it often or very often.
- The main difficulties are complementary skills (31.2%), availability (29.2%) and similar goals (18.8%).
- Insight: TeamUp should make discovery more structured than group chats, around skills, availability, goals and project needs.

Forming Teams

- Behaviour matters as much as skill. Respondents rated teamwork (76.6%), reliability/commitment (74.5%), communication (72.3%) and ability to meet deadlines (70.2%) as important (4 or 5 out of 5), compared with relevant skills (64.6%).
- Similar experience level mattered least (31.9%).
- Insight: matching should use complementary skills plus availability and commitment, not seniority. Availability should be visible before someone joins a team.

Staying Functional

- What keeps people committed: active team communication (68.8%), clear roles and responsibilities (66.7%), team accountability (52.1%), regular progress tracking (43.8%) and defined deadlines (41.7%).
- Other leading causes of inactivity: lack of accountability (39.6%), busy schedules (37.5%) and unclear responsibilities (37.5%).
- 31.3% are uncomfortable with performance or conflict conversations, so some teams may let inactivity continue.
- Insight: team health is a core product concern. TeamUp needs explicit commitment, clear roles, visible progress and a defined process for missed commitments.

Completing Projects

- Half of respondents have seen a project abandoned, so completion cannot be assumed once a team forms.
- Respondents most valued skill-based collaborator discovery (64.6%), people with similar interests and goals (60.4%) and real-world projects (56.2%). Team accountability and progress tracking was chosen by 45.8%.
- Insight: TeamUp should be designed as a journey, not a people directory. The build and complete stages matter as much as matching.

Showing Evidence

- The most valued evidence of contribution is a completed project or product (72.9%), followed by project documentation (58.3%), client feedback or testimonials (43.8%) and a live product or website (37.5%).

- 47.9% valued portfolio evidence from completed projects as a TeamUp feature, and 12.5% said proving their contribution is a challenge.
- Insight: contribution records should be tied to a completed outcome and supporting evidence, not stand alone.

Demand Signal and Limits

- 41 of the 46 respondents who answered (89.1%) said they were likely or very likely to use a platform like TeamUp.
- This is directional validation of stated interest, not proof of adoption. The sample is small (48) and appears to be a convenience sample. Behaviour still needs to be tested through interviews, prototype testing and an MVP cohort.

From Research to Product

Research Finding	Implication for TeamUp
Complementary skills are the top collaborator challenge.	Matching accounts for skill gaps and project role requirements.
Availability is a barrier and busy schedules cause inactivity.	Capture weekly availability, duration and commitment before joining.
Reliability, teamwork and communication are highly valued.	Profile and matching signals include working style, not skills alone.
Lack of commitment is the leading cause of inactivity.	Set commitment expectations before team formation.
Communication and clear roles drive commitment.	Provide central team communication and role ownership.
Accountability and progress tracking help; teams chase missed deadlines manually.	Use milestones, task ownership and visible progress, with a structured follow-up and reassignment workflow.

Research Finding	Implication for TeamUp
Completed projects are the strongest evidence; some users struggle to prove contribution.	Generate evidence from completed projects and track contributions throughout.

4. Target Users & Personas

Primary Users

- Digital skill learners completing courses, bootcamps or self-directed learning.
- Beginners and fresh graduates who need first project experience.
- Career switchers who need evidence in a newly learned field.
- Early-career professionals who want to practise skills outside their current job.
- Freelancers looking for practical projects and collaborators.

In the survey, respondents were mostly job seekers (35.4%), students or fresh graduates (20.8%), freelancers (18.8%) and working professionals (16.7%). About 29% were beginners and 38% had one to two years of experience. The most common skills were data analytics (37.5%), digital marketing and frontend development (22.9% each), and product design/UI/UX (18.8%).

Secondary Users (Later)

- Experienced professionals who want to mentor or contribute to selected projects.
- Bootcamps, communities and schools that need structured project teams for learners.

Priority Personas

These three personas are illustrative archetypes built from the research. Details such as availability are assumptions to confirm in interviews.

	Ada Junior Product Manager	**David** UI/UX Designer	**Tola** Career Switcher, Data Analytics
Profile	Recently completed a PM course; learning or early-career.	Early-career designer with one to two years of experience, mostly practice projects.	Job seeker who recently learned data analytics, the most common skill in the survey.
Has	PRD knowledge, frameworks and coursework.	Figma skills and design principles.	Tools, dashboards and coursework.
Needs	A designer, developers and a real product to manage.	A real product context, developers to build with and user feedback.	A real business problem, stakeholders and teammates who stay engaged.
Availability	About 5 hours per week for a 4 to 6 week project.	To be confirmed in interviews.	To be confirmed in interviews.
Goal	Real project experience and proof of the work she led.	A shipped project with design work he can show, such as onboarding and dashboard flows.	A completed project with documented outcomes for job applications.
Pain Point	Has no team and no product to apply her PM skills to.	Designs stay as mockups because he cannot find a team that builds.	Has been on a team where members went inactive and the project was abandoned.

5. Goals, Objectives & Success Criteria

Goals and North Star

Product Goal	User Goal
Help users form functional teams that successfully complete practical projects.	Leave the platform with meaningful project experience and evidence of contribution.

NORTH STAR

Completed projects that produce real contribution evidence.

The North Star is preferred over registrations or matches because it measures the actual promise of TeamUp: users finish something real and can show what they did.

MVP Objectives

- Make it easy to find collaborators with complementary skills and compatible availability.
- Make commitment explicit before work begins, including role, time and deadlines.
- Keep teams functional through clear roles, milestones, progress visibility and lightweight accountability.
- Record individual contributions throughout the project.
- Produce a shareable project page for each completed project.

Success Criteria

Success will be judged by how well users move through the journey. Targets will be set after the first pilot cohort. Full definitions are in MVP Requirements, Priorities & Success Metrics.

Metric	What It Shows
Team formation rate	Projects that reach the required team.
Team activation rate	Newly formed teams that begin work.
First milestone completion	Teams that complete their first milestone.
Project completion rate	Started projects that are completed.
Contribution-record completion	Completed projects with contribution records.
Inactive-member recovery	Inactive members who return or are replaced.
Repeat participation	Users who start another project after completing one.

6. Scope & Non-Scope

We have limited time, so the MVP includes only what is needed to prove the core TeamUp journey: find people, form a team, build, complete and document.

MVP In Scope	Out of Scope for MVP
• User profile • Skills • Interests and goals • Availability • Project creation • Project discovery • Collaborator discovery and matching (rule-based for the	• Job marketplace • Social feed • Advanced AI matching • Complex mentor marketplace • Advanced portfolio analytics • Anything not required to prove the core TeamUp journey

MVP In Scope	Out of Scope for MVP
MVP) • Team formation • Roles and responsibilities • Tasks • Deadlines • Progress tracking • Task comments and team updates thread • Contribution tracking • Project completion and evidence	

Scope Principle

If a feature does not help users form a team, keep it functional, complete the project or document contributions, it waits until the core behaviour is proven.

Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Potential Consequence	Mitigation
Ghosting or low commitment	Projects fail to complete.	Capture availability and commitment; use milestones and contribution visibility.
Poor matching	Users lose trust in recommendations.	Start with transparent matching criteria and let users set project requirements.

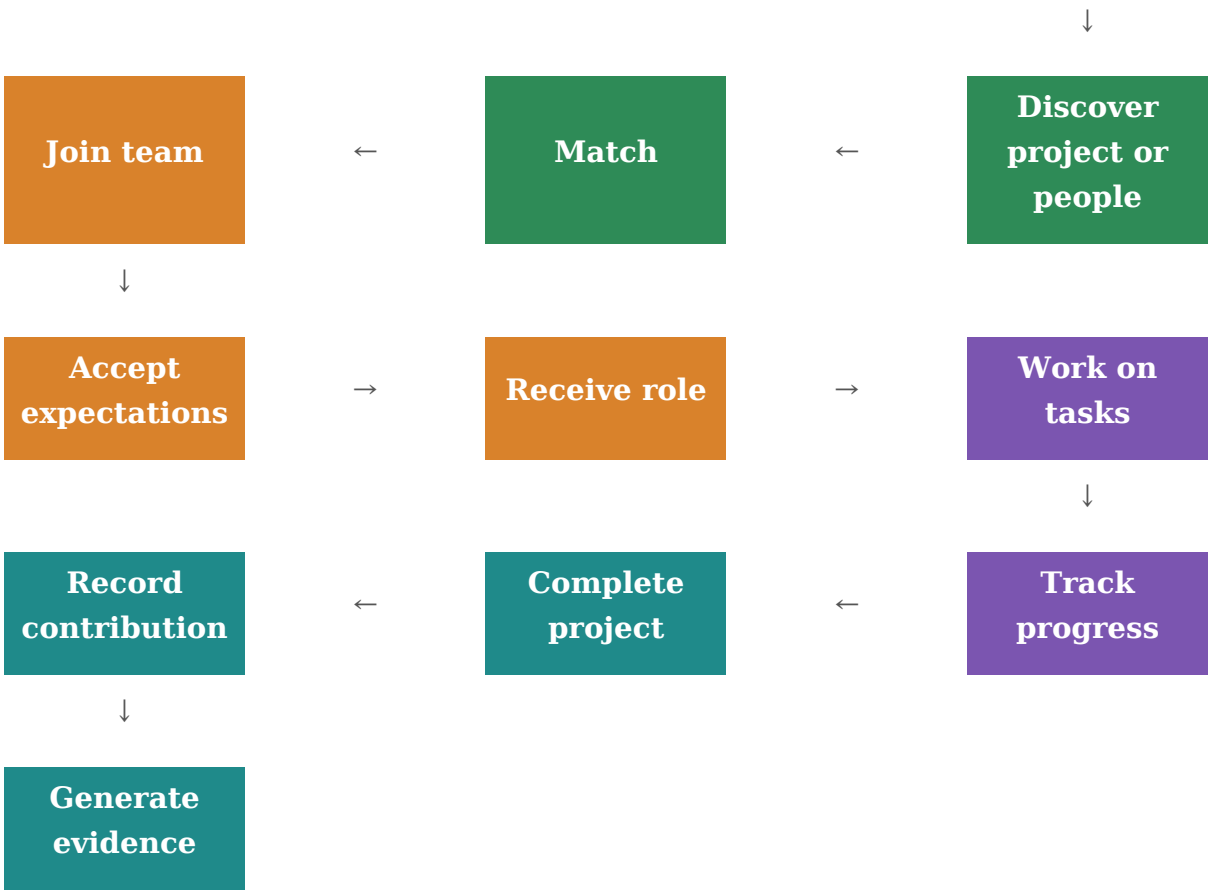
Risk	Potential Consequence	Mitigation
Platform becomes another social network	Weak differentiation.	Keep projects and outcomes at the centre of the experience.
Users create projects but do not finish them	No practical evidence is produced.	Use short project durations, milestones and completion prompts.
Many want to join but few create projects	Supply and demand imbalance.	Offer project templates and encourage organisation or cohort project creation.
Contribution evidence is disputed	Portfolio records may be unreliable.	Use peer confirmation, project artifacts and transparent contribution logs; avoid claiming formal verification without evidence.
Existing products overlap	Difficult acquisition and differentiation.	Focus on the learning-to-experience use case and validate that the full workflow adds enough value.

7. User Journey / End-to-End Flow

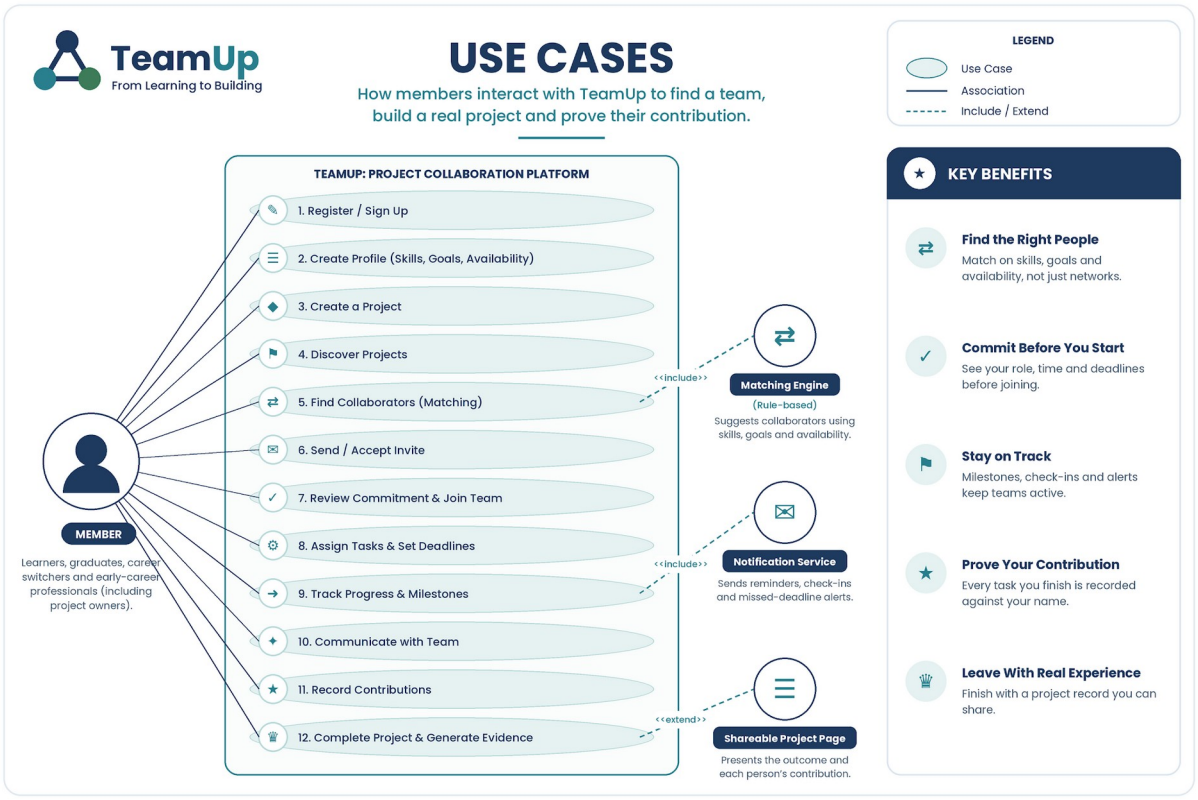
This part maps the full experience a user has on TeamUp, from sign-up to evidence of contribution. The journey gives the build and completion stages the same weight as matching, since these stages decide whether a team finishes and has anything to show.

Journey diagram





The journey moves through five phases. Each phase is described below with what the user does, what TeamUp does in response, and the reasoning behind the design.



Phase 1: Onboarding (sign up, create profile, add skills, goals and availability)

The user signs up and builds a short profile: role, skills, skill level, goals, weekly availability and preferred project duration. TeamUp keeps this step short so that users reach their first project or match quickly. Interests and collaboration preferences are asked at first match, and optional fields can be added later. Availability is captured here, before any matching, because finding available people was the second-largest collaboration barrier (29.2%) and busy schedules were a leading cause of inactivity (37.5%).

Phase 2: Discovery and matching (discover project or people, match)

Users take one of two entry paths. A joiner browses open projects and sees where their skills fit. A project owner browses collaborators to fill open roles. In both cases TeamUp shows a match result with reasons. The first time a user opens discovery, TeamUp asks for their interests and collaboration preferences, so both are in place before the first ranked matches are shown. Finding real projects was the top portfolio

challenge (58.3%), and skill-based collaborator discovery was the most valued feature (64.6%), so both paths are central rather than optional.

Phase 3: Commitment (join team, accept expectations, receive role)

Before anyone joins, they review the role, expected contribution, time commitment, duration, deadlines and team expectations, and explicitly accept them. Only then do they receive their role and enter the team. Commitment is explicit before the work begins. The detail is under Team Formation & Commitment.

Phase 4: Building (work on tasks, track progress)

The team works in a shared workspace with tasks, owners, deadlines, milestones and visible progress. This is where TeamUp moves beyond being a matching platform. Respondents said active communication, clear roles, accountability and progress tracking would keep them committed, and the workspace is built around those four things.

Phase 5: Completion and evidence (complete project, record contribution, generate evidence)

When the project is finished, each member's contributions are confirmed and TeamUp generates a project page with the outcome, each person's role and their individual contributions. A completed project or product was the most valued evidence of contribution (72.9%), so evidence is always tied to a real outcome.

Example journey: Ada, junior Product Manager

Ada signs up and sets up her profile with PM skills, five hours a week of availability and a preferred duration of four to six weeks. She finds Campus Marketplace, a project that needs a Product Manager. TeamUp matches her with a designer and developers who fit the project's needs. She reviews the role, hours and deadlines, accepts them, and joins. The team works through milestones, roles and a prototype. At the end, Ada has a contribution record and a shareable project page. She leaves with proof of work, not just a certificate.

Journey design principles

- Commitment is explicit before work begins, never assumed.
- Availability is visible before team formation, not discovered afterwards.
- Every step should be short and have one clear next action.
- Contribution is recorded throughout the project, not reconstructed at the end.
- Support for struggling teams should feel lightweight, not like surveillance (see Accountability & Team Health).

8. User Profiles

A TeamUp profile exists for one purpose: to help TeamUp form a better team. Every field must pass a single test: does this help TeamUp match people to projects or help a team work together? Fields that do not pass the test are not collected.

To keep sign-up short, information is collected in three stages: a small set of fields at sign-up, two fields at first match, and optional fields later.

Profile fields

Field	Why it helps form a better team	Collected at
Name	Identifies the person to teammates and appears on the project page.	Sign-up
Professional role	States the role the person wants to play (for example Product Manager, UI/UX Designer, Developer), which drives role-based matching.	Sign-up
Skills	Core input for complementary-skills matching, the top collaborator-finding challenge (31.2%).	Sign-up
Skill level	Helps place a person in the right role. It is used for role fit, not for matching	Sign-up

	by seniority, because similar experience level was the least important selection factor (31.9% rated it 4 or 5).	
Goals	Helps align people who want the same outcome from a project (for example portfolio piece or first experience). Similar goals ranked as the third collaboration challenge (18.8%).	Sign-up
Availability (hours per week)	Prevents poor-fit teams. Finding available people was a major barrier (29.2%).	Sign-up
Preferred project duration	Matches people to projects whose length they can realistically commit to.	Sign-up
Interests	Supports matching people to projects they will stay interested in. Loss of interest was a top inactivity cause (52.1%).	First match
Collaboration preferences	Captures working style, preferred communication channel and expected response time. Communication was the most important quality of an easy teammate (58.3%).	First match
Previous project experience	Gives context on past teamwork. Useful but secondary (41.7% rated it 4 or 5).	Optional, later
Portfolio, GitHub or LinkedIn links	Helps teammates verify skills, which respondents named as a trust signal. Shown only where relevant to the person's role.	Optional, later

Profile principles

- Collect only what is needed to get started at sign-up, ask for interests and collaboration preferences at first match, and keep everything else optional.
- Availability and collaboration preferences are shown on the profile and used in matching, because behavioural fit and availability matter at least as much as technical fit.
- Users control what is public. Contact details are never shown to others before a user joins a team.
- TeamUp does not collect information that does not improve team formation, such as date of birth or unrelated personal details.
- Past project completions on TeamUp will later appear on the profile as a credibility signal (see Contribution Tracking).

9. Project Creation

TeamUp matches people around projects, not just profiles, so a well-defined project is the foundation of every good team. Any user can create a project. The user who creates a project automatically becomes its project owner, who reviews join requests and keeps the project on track. Because the most common way teams currently manage tasks is for one person to assign them (39.6%), a clear owner role reflects real behaviour.

Project fields

Field	What it captures
Project name	A short, clear title.
Problem or opportunity	The real-world problem the project addresses. This makes the project credible as portfolio evidence.
Description	What will be built or delivered and how the team will work.
Project type	Categories such as web app, mobile app, data

	analysis, marketing campaign or design project, used for discovery filters.
Skills required	The skills the project needs overall, used for matching.
Number of team members needed	Team size, so TeamUp knows when the team is complete.
Roles required	Each role with its responsibilities and the skills it needs (for example Product Manager, UI/UX Designer, Frontend Developer).
Expected duration	Total length of the project, for example four to six weeks.
Time commitment	Expected hours per week for each role.
Availability expectations	When the team needs to be reachable, such as meeting days or response windows.
Milestones	At least one milestone with a target date is required to publish, and two or more are recommended. Milestones become the backbone of progress tracking.
Expected outcome or deliverable	What the team will have at the end (for example a working prototype with documentation).

Creation flow

The creator starts a project, describes the problem and outcome, defines roles and time commitment, sets milestones, and publishes. The project then appears in discovery as open. A project cannot be published without at least one defined role, a duration, a time commitment and one milestone, because these are the details a joiner needs to make an informed commitment. Two or more milestones are recommended, so progress can be checked at more than one point.

Project status

- Draft
- Open
- Team Formed
- In Progress
- Completed
- Ended Early

A project can reach either Completed or Ended Early, depending on its outcome.

10. Collaborator Discovery & Matching

MVP Matching Approach

For the MVP, TeamUp will use rule-based filtering to help users discover suitable projects and collaborators. Users will be able to browse and filter by relevant skills, role, project type, project duration and weekly availability. The system will exclude collaborators who do not meet a role's required skill or weekly availability.

Ranked compatibility scores, compatibility labels, match explanations and partial-match suggestions are planned as Should Have features and may be introduced after the core matching experience has been validated.

Two discovery experiences

- **Project discovery:** a user browses or filters open projects and sees how well each role fits their skills, goals and availability.
- **Collaborator discovery:** a project owner browses or filters people for an open role and sees how well each person fits the project's requirements.

How matching works

For the MVP, matching uses rule-based filtering to help users discover suitable projects and collaborators. Ranked compatibility scores, match

labels, explanations and partial-match suggestions are Should Have features that may be introduced if capacity allows or after the core matching experience has been validated. The ranking signals and weights below are proposed hypotheses for future testing, not features guaranteed for the MVP.

Step one: required filters. A person must have the skill the role requires and enough weekly availability to meet the role's time commitment. The project's duration should also fit their preferred duration.

Step two: ranking signals. These are listed below with starting weights, which are a hypothesis to test rather than findings from the research.

Signal	How it is used	Starting weight (hypothesis)
Complementary skills	Does the person fill a skill gap in the project or team?	35%
Availability	How closely weekly hours and timing fit the project's expectations.	25%
Goals and interests	Overlap between the person's goals and interests and the project's purpose.	20%
Collaboration preferences	Compatibility of communication style and expected response time.	15%
Experience level	Fit between skill level and the role's difficulty, not equal seniority.	5%

These percentages are not taken from the survey. They are a starting hypothesis to be tested and tuned during prototype testing. The direction follows the research: skills and availability were the two biggest barriers to finding collaborators, reliability, teamwork and communication ranked above relevant skills when respondents choose teammates, and similar

experience level ranked lowest. Availability and collaboration preferences together carry 40% of the ranking, more than skills (35%), so working fit counts for at least as much as technical fit.

MVP boundary: The MVP provides rule-based discovery and filtering. Compatibility labels, match explanations, ranked results and closest partial-match suggestions are Should Have features and will only be included if sprint capacity allows. The following details describe the proposed enhanced matching experience, not a guaranteed MVP deliverable.

What users see

- A simple compatibility label (for example strong, good or partial match) rather than a precise score, which keeps the experience honest for a rule-based system.
- A short explanation of why the match works, such as the skill gap it fills and the availability overlap.
- Filters for skill, role, project type, duration and weekly hours.
- clear next action: request to join, or invite the person.

A. Behavioural compatibility

Reliability, teamwork and communication ranked above relevant skills and experience in how respondents choose teammates. For the MVP, TeamUp reflects this through declared collaboration preferences and availability. As projects complete on the platform, completion history can become a reliability signal in a later version. We do not claim to measure reliability before there is data to support it.

B. Edge cases

If there are no strong matches, TeamUp shows the closest partial matches and explains what is missing (for example, no available designer yet). The owner can then adjust the role requirements or wait for more users.

11. Team Formation & Commitment

The strongest lever for keeping a team functional is to make commitment explicit before the work begins. In the survey, the leading reasons for inactivity were lack of commitment (62.5%), poor communication (56.2%) and loss of interest (52.1%), followed by lack of accountability, busy schedules and unclear responsibilities (between 37.5% and 39.6%). The steps below respond to these by making the role, time and expectations clear before anyone joins. Accountability during the build is covered under Accountability & Team Health.

Formation flow

Project, then view requirements, then request or accept an invite, then review commitment, then join the team.

- **View requirements:** the user sees the project's problem, outcome, role, skills, duration, time commitment and milestones.
- **Request or accept an invite:** a joiner requests a role, or an owner invites a matched collaborator, who can accept or decline.
- **Review commitment:** before the user can join, TeamUp shows the commitment summary described below.
- **Join team:** once the user accepts, they receive the role and gain access to the workspace.

The commitment summary

Before joining, the user must see and accept the following:

- Their role and its responsibilities.
- Expected contribution, meaning the main tasks or deliverables tied to the role.
- Time commitment per week.
- Project duration and start date.
- Key deadlines and milestones.
- Team expectations, described below.

Team expectations

Every team shares a short set of working agreements that the project owner can adjust. They are intentionally light, and cover the behaviours the research links to functional teams:

- Respond to team messages within an agreed window.
- Update task status when it changes.
- Tell the team early if you are unavailable or at risk of missing a deadline.
- Raise blockers rather than waiting until a deadline passes.

Acceptance and recording

The user accepts through an explicit confirmation step, and TeamUp records the acceptance with the date. This record lets the team refer back to what was agreed if expectations are missed. It is a shared agreement, not a penalty.

Forming and starting the team

The project owner reviews join requests against the project's needs. A team is formed when the required roles are filled, and the project can start once the owner confirms the kick-off. If a user changes their mind before the project starts, they can withdraw without consequence. After the project starts, leaving goes through a handover so the team is not left to absorb the work. The full process for inactivity, reassignment and replacement is covered under Accountability & Team Health.

12. Team Workspace & Collaboration

The workspace is where a formed team does its work. It keeps coordination in one purpose-built place, because progress is currently scattered across meetings (41.7%), project tools (20.8%) and messaging apps (20.8%). It should feel like a simple shared project room, not a heavy project-management suite.

A. Workspace components

Component	What the team can do
Team members and roles	See every member, their role, their responsibilities and their weekly availability.
Tasks	Create tasks, assign each to one owner, and link it to a milestone.
Deadlines	Every task has a due date, which is visible to the whole team.
Status tracking	Move tasks through simple statuses: to do, in progress, in review, done and blocked.
Milestones	See milestones, their target dates and how many tasks are complete.
Project progress	View an overall progress indicator built from completed tasks and milestones.
Blockers	Flag a task as blocked with a short note so the team can see risks early.
Communication	Comment on tasks and post to a team updates thread, so conversation stays connected to the work. Full in-app chat is a Should Have.

Basic task status tracking is a Must Have feature. The extended workflow, including the In Review and Blocked statuses and blocker notes, may be prioritised as a Should Have feature for the MVP.

Communication in the MVP

Task comments and a team updates thread are Must Have in the MVP, and full in-app chat is Should Have. Active team communication was the strongest commitment driver in the survey (68.8%), so the Must Have version keeps team conversation attached to the work itself.

Roles in the workspace

Task Assignment and Permissions: For the MVP, teams must be able to assign tasks to members and set task deadlines. Members must be able to view and update the status of their assigned tasks.

Advanced owner controls, including task reassignment, role management and membership management, are planned as Should Have features.

Design principles

- **Lightweight:** a few clear screens and actions, so the workspace supports collaboration without feeling like surveillance.
- **Visible:** progress, owners and deadlines are shown to everyone, which makes accountability natural rather than enforced.
- **Connected:** every completed task feeds the contribution record, so work is captured as it happens.

13. Accountability & Team Health

Matching people well is not enough. Teams also have to stay functional until the project is finished. TeamUp does this with a lightweight system built on three ideas: make commitment explicit, make progress visible and make inactivity actionable. The system supports teams. It does not police them.

Today, teams mostly handle missed deadlines by hand. Half of respondents (50.0%) said the team follows up with the person, and 35.4% said someone else takes over the task. TeamUp replaces this informal chasing with a defined process that is gentle, visible and led by people.

MVP boundary: The baseline MVP includes clear task ownership, deadlines, visible progress, overdue flags, reminders and overdue prompts, the ability to release a role and reopen it for a replacement, and team communication. Automated inactivity detection, weekly check-ins, guided reassignment and owner escalation are Should Have enhancements and depend on available sprint capacity.

How TeamUp keeps teams functional

Stage	What TeamUp provides
Before the work starts	Explicit commitment, clear roles and visible availability, covered under Team Formation & Commitment.
While the work runs	Task owners and deadlines, milestones, progress tracking, check-ins, and task comments with a team updates thread.
When something slips	Reminders, overdue prompts, inactivity detection, follow-up, reassignment, and replacement or escalation where necessary.

Progress tracking

Progress is calculated automatically from task statuses and milestones, so nobody has to write status reports. Everyone on the team sees the same progress, and tasks past their due date are flagged as overdue. The workspace also shows a simple team health status. It always carries a text label, so it never relies on colour alone.

Team health status	When it applies (starting rule)
On track	No overdue or blocked tasks, and no missed check-ins.
Needs attention	At least one overdue or blocked task, or a missed check-in.
At risk	A milestone is overdue, or a member has been flagged as inactive.

Check-ins

Each team has a short weekly check-in on the team updates thread. Every member answers three quick prompts: what I completed, what I

am doing next, and whether anything is blocking me. It should take under a minute. The project owner can change the check-in day, and a missed check-in only prompts a gentle reminder. It carries no penalty.

Deadlines, reminders and overdue prompts

Every task has an owner and a due date. The task owner gets one reminder before the task is due. If the due date passes, the owner is asked to respond with one tap: mark it done, request a new date, or hand it over. This makes a missed deadline visible early and gives the person an easy way to respond before the team has to chase them.

Inactivity detection

TeamUp treats a member as inactive when they have had no task update, comment or check-in for five days and have not marked themselves as away. Logging in alone does not count as activity. Detection only looks at activity inside TeamUp, and members can see exactly what counts. A member who knows they will be unavailable can mark an away period, which pauses detection and tells teammates when to expect them back.

Follow-up, reassignment and replacement

When a commitment slips, TeamUp guides the team through a short sequence. Each step is a prompt for people to act on, and nothing happens to a person automatically.

Step	When it starts (starting rule)	What happens
Reminder	One day before a task is due.	The task owner gets a short reminder.
Overdue prompt	The task passes its due date.	The task owner is asked to mark it done, request a new date or hand it over. The team sees the overdue flag.
Follow-up	No response within two days of the overdue	The project owner is notified and offered a suggested message to send. The member receives a friendly

	prompt, or no activity for five days.	check-in with three options: I am back, I need to reduce my hours, or I need to step away.
Reassignment	No response after a further two days, or the member asks to hand over.	The owner reassigns the open tasks and the team is told. The contribution record credits whoever completes the work.
Replacement	The member steps away, or stays inactive after reassignment.	The owner releases the role. It reopens in discovery so a replacement can be matched, and the departing member's work so far is kept.
Escalation	The project owner is inactive, or the team cannot agree.	The remaining members can nominate a new owner.

Suggested follow-up messages matter because nearly a third of respondents (31.3%) are uncomfortable with performance conversations, so TeamUp gives the owner the words to start one. Whether a structured sequence works better than generic reminders is a hypothesis to test in prototype testing, and the timings above are starting values to tune with the first cohort.

What TeamUp avoids

Accountability must support collaboration without feeling like workplace surveillance. TeamUp therefore does not track hours or screen time, does not score or rank members, does not call people out publicly, and limits reminders so that nobody is flooded with notifications.

14. Contribution Tracking

TeamUp records what each person actually contributed, and it records it as the work happens. Some respondents (12.5%) named difficulty proving their contribution as a portfolio challenge. Tracking contribution throughout the project means nobody has to reconstruct it from memory at the end.

What is recorded

For each member, TeamUp keeps their role, the tasks they completed with dates and milestones, the deliverables they attached (links or files), and a short note in their own words where they choose to add one. A teammate confirms each summary before it appears on the final project page.

TeamUp does not record hours worked, lines of code or message counts. Contribution means work delivered, not activity.

How the record builds

When a member marks a task done, it is added to their record automatically. They can attach a link or file and add a one-line note at that moment. At completion, the system prepares a summary grouped by each member’s role. Member review and editing of the summary before finalisation is a Should Have enhancement. A teammate must confirm each summary before it appears on the project page. If a member disputes a statement about their contribution, the team should resolve the wording before the page is shared; the detailed dispute-resolution workflow can be refined during testing.

Example contribution record

Member	Role	Recorded contributions
Ada	Product Manager	Created user stories, conducted research, defined requirements, and managed the sprint.

David	UI/UX Designer	Designed onboarding, created the dashboard, conducted usability testing.
John	Developer	Built authentication, developed the dashboard, integrated the API.

Reassigned tasks and early exits

Credit follows completion. If a task is reassigned, the person who finishes it is credited, and a handover note keeps any earlier work visible. A member who leaves early keeps a record of what they completed, shown as a partial contribution, so honest work is never lost and nobody's role is overstated.

Where the record is used

The contribution record feeds the project page described under Project Completion & Portfolio Evidence, and it is the basis of the contribution-record completion metric. Completed projects can also appear on a member's profile, and each member chooses whether they do.

15. Project Completion & Portfolio Evidence

A finished project should never be recorded as just "Project completed." TeamUp builds a project page that answers one question: what did you actually do? A completed project or product was the most valued evidence of contribution (72.9%), followed by project documentation (58.3%), so the page is built around real deliverables and documentation. Screenshots and designs were the least valued evidence type (16.7%), so they are optional.

Completion flow

When the milestones are done, the project owner starts a completion checklist. The checklist requires a final outcome statement, at least one deliverable (a link or file), and a confirmed contribution summary for every member. Additional prompts for project documentation, a live

product link, screenshots and measurable results are Should Have enhancements. Once the required items are complete, the project is marked Completed and TeamUp generates the project page.

What the project page contains

Section	What it shows	At completion
Project overview	Name and short description, taken from project creation.	Automatic
Problem solved	The problem or opportunity the project addressed.	Automatic
Final outcome	What the team delivered, including any measurable results.	Required
Team members and roles	Everyone on the team and their role.	Automatic
Individual contributions	Each member's confirmed contributions.	Required
Deliverables	Links and files produced by the team.	Required (at least one)
Project documentation	Documents that explain how the project was built and what it does.	Prompted
Links and screenshots	Supporting links and images.	Optional
Live product	A link to the working product, where applicable.	Optional

Answering "What did you do?"

Each member's contributions appear beside their name and role, with a marker showing that teammates confirmed them. Members can view and share a version of the page that puts their own contribution first, so the page works as personal evidence as well as a team record.

Sharing and privacy

The project page is private to the team until the members choose to share it through a link. Each member decides whether the project appears on their own profile.

Projects that cannot be finished

A team can close a project as it ends early. The work done and the contributions confirmed so far are kept, but the page is not presented as a completed project. This keeps the project completion rate honest and still protects the work people put in.

16. Functional Requirements

Each requirement is written so that it can become a backlog item. Priority follows the levels defined under MVP Requirements, Priorities & Success Metrics. Must Have is limited to what is needed to prove the core journey: find a team, join with commitment, work on tasks and finish with evidence.

Core journey

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-01	Users must be able to create a profile.	**Must Have**
FR-02	Users must be able to add skills.	**Must Have**
FR-03	Users must be able to specify availability.	**Must**

		Have
FR-04	Users must be able to create projects.	**Must Have**
FR-05	Users must be able to specify required skills.	**Must Have**
FR-06	Users must be able to discover compatible collaborators.	**Must Have**
FR-07	Users must be able to join a project after reviewing expectations.	**Must Have**
FR-08	Teams must be able to assign tasks.	**Must Have**
FR-09	Tasks must have deadlines.	**Must Have**
FR-10	Team members must be able to track task status.	**Must Have**

Profiles and onboarding

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-11	Users must be able to sign up and log in.	**Must Have**
FR-12	The profile must capture name, professional role, skill level, goals and preferred project duration at sign-up.	**Must Have**
FR-13	Users must be asked for their interests and collaboration preferences the first time they open discovery, before ranked matches are shown.	**Should Have**
FR-14	Users must be able to add previous project experience and portfolio, GitHub or LinkedIn	**Should**

	links as optional profile fields.	**Have**
FR-15	Contact details must remain hidden from other users until they are on the same team. Users must be able to control which profile information is publicly visible.	**Must Have**

Projects

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-16	A project must capture its name, problem or opportunity, description, project type, expected duration, time commitment, availability expectations and expected outcome.	Must Have
FR-17	Project owners must be able to define the roles needed, the number of team members, and the skills and responsibilities of each role.	Must Have
FR-18	Project owners must be able to add milestones with target dates.	Must Have
FR-19	A project must not be publishable without at least one role, a duration, a time commitment and one milestone, and the system must recommend two or more milestones.	Must Have
FR-20	Projects must have a visible status: draft, open, team formed, in progress, completed or ended early.	Must Have

Matching and discovery

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-21	Users must be able to browse and filter open projects by skill, role, project type, duration and	Must Have

	weekly hours.	
FR-22	Project owners must be able to browse and filter collaborators for an open role.	Must Have
FR-23	The system must exclude people who lack the skills required for a role, do not have sufficient weekly availability, or cannot commit to the project’s expected duration.	Must Have
FR-24	The system must rank the remaining matches using complementary skills, availability, goals and interests, collaboration preferences and experience level.	Should Have
FR-25	The system must show a compatibility label and a short explanation of why each match fits.	Should Have
FR-26	When no strong match exists, the system must show the closest partial matches and explain what is missing.	Should Have

Team formation and commitment

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-27	Users must be able to request a role on a project, and owners must be able to invite matched collaborators.	Must Have
FR-28	Owners must be able to accept or decline join requests, and invited users must be able to accept or decline invitations.	Must Have
FR-29	Before joining, users must see a commitment summary covering their role, expected contribution, weekly time commitment, project duration, deadlines and team expectations.	Must Have

FR-30	Users must explicitly accept the commitment summary before they can access the team workspace, and the system must record the acceptance with the date.	Must Have
FR-31	Project owners must be able to adjust the default team expectations.	Should Have
FR-32	Project owners must be able to confirm the kick-off once the required roles are filled.	Should Have
FR-33	Members must be able to withdraw before kick-off without consequence, and to leave after kick-off through a handover of their open tasks.	Should Have

Team workspace

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-34	The workspace must show every member with their role, responsibilities and weekly availability.	Must Have
FR-35	Tasks must be linkable to a milestone.	Must Have
FR-36	Task statuses must be to do, in progress, in review, done and blocked, and a blocked task must carry a short note.	Must Have
FR-37	The workspace must show milestone progress and an overall project progress indicator.	Must Have
FR-38	Members must be able to comment on tasks and post to a team updates thread.	Must Have
FR-39	Teams must be able to use full in-app chat.	Should Have

FR-40	Project owners must be able to assign and reassign tasks and manage roles and membership, and members must be able to manage their own tasks.	Must Have

Accountability and team health

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-41	Overdue tasks must be flagged to the whole team.	Must Have
FR-42	The workspace must show a team health status (on track, needs attention or at risk) with a text label.	Should Have
FR-43	Teams must be able to run a weekly check-in where each member shares what they completed, what is next and any blockers.	Should Have
FR-44	Task owners must receive a reminder before a task is due, and a prompt when it becomes overdue to mark it done, request a new date or hand it over.	Must Have
FR-45	The system must detect inactivity from task updates, comments and check-ins inside TeamUp, and notify the member and the project owner.	Should Have
FR-46	Members must be able to mark an away period that pauses inactivity detection.	Should Have
FR-47	The system must offer the project owner a suggested follow-up message for an inactive member.	Should Have
FR-48	The system must guide the owner through reassigning an inactive member's open tasks.	Should Have

FR-49	Owners must be able to release a member's role and reopen it in discovery for a replacement.	Must Have
FR-50	If the project owner is inactive, the remaining members must be able to nominate a new owner.	Could Have

Contribution tracking

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-51	Completing a task must add it to the assignee's contribution record automatically.	Must Have
FR-52	Members must be able to attach a link or file to a completed task. Adding a short explanatory note is optional.	Must Have
FR-53	Members must be able to review and edit their contribution summary before it is finalized.	Must Have
FR-54	At least one teammate must confirm each member's contribution summary before it appears on the project page.	Must Have
FR-55	When a task is reassigned, the contribution record must credit the person who completes it and keep a handover note on earlier work.	Should Have
FR-56	Members who leave early must keep a record of the work they completed, shown as a partial contribution.	Should Have

Completion and evidence

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-57	Project owners must be able to mark a project complete once the completion checklist is done.	Must Have

FR-58	The completion checklist must require a final outcome statement, at least one deliverable and a confirmed contribution summary for every member.	Must Have
FR-59	The system must generate a project page showing the project overview, problem solved, final outcome, team members and roles, individual contributions and deliverables.	Must Have
FR-60	Teams must be able to add supporting project documentation, additional links and a live product link to the project page where applicable.	Should Have
FR-61	Teams must be able to add screenshots to the project page.	Should Have
FR-62	The project page must show which contributions were confirmed by teammates.	Should Have
FR-63	Each member must be able to view and share a version of the project page that highlights their own contribution.	Should Have
FR-64	The project page must stay private to the team until members choose to share it through a link, and each member must be able to choose whether the project appears on their profile.	Must Have
FR-65	Teams must be able to close a project as ended early and keep the record of the work completed.	Should Have

Account, notifications and project ownership

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR-66	Users must be able to edit their profile data and request deletion of their account.	Should Have

FR-67	Users must be able to adjust their notification settings, with reminders capped.	Should Have
FR-68	The person who creates a project must become its project owner.	Must Have

17. Non-Functional Requirements & Constraints

These requirements are deliberately simple for the MVP. Numeric targets are starting values to validate during testing.

Area	Requirement
Mobile responsiveness	All core flows must work on phone, tablet and desktop screens without sideways scrolling.
Performance	Target: key pages load within three seconds on a typical mobile connection, and match results appear within two seconds.
Security and privacy	Users must log in to access TeamUp. Passwords must be stored securely, never in plain text. Only team members can see a team workspace, and all traffic must use HTTPS.
Accessibility	Follow WCAG 2.1 AA basics: sufficient colour contrast, keyboard navigation, labelled form fields, and status shown with text as well as colour.
Reliability	Tasks, check-ins and contribution records must not be lost. Data is saved as users work and backed up regularly.
Notifications	In-app notifications first, with email for invitations, deadlines and inactivity prompts. Messages must be short, actionable and never shaming. Reminders are

	capped and users can adjust their settings.
Data protection	Collect only the data needed to form better teams. Users must be able to edit their profile data and request deletion of their account. TeamUp must comply with the data protection laws that apply to its users.
Scalability	The MVP is built for a small first cohort, but the design should allow more users and projects, and later AI matching, without a rebuild. Matching rules and weights should be configurable so they can be tuned during testing.

Constraints and assumptions

- Time: the MVP is a six-week project with two build sprints followed by a testing sprint, so the first build focuses on Must Have items.
- Skills are self-reported in the MVP. Credibility comes from linked work and teammate-confirmed contributions rather than skill verification.
- Matching quality depends on having enough users and open projects in the first cohort.
- Notifications are limited to in-app and email in the MVP.
- Team health rules, including timings and thresholds, are starting values to be tested and tuned with the first cohort.

18. MVP Requirements, Priorities & Success Metrics

This part defines what gets built first. Must Have items are the minimum needed to prove the core journey: find a team, join with commitment, work on tasks and finish with evidence. Should Have items strengthen it and are built if sprint capacity allows. Could have items wait until the core behaviour is proven.

Must Have

- Profile
- Skills
- Availability
- Project creation, including milestones
- Collaborator discovery
- Team formation, including the commitment summary
- Roles, with owner and member permissions
- Tasks, with task statuses and blocker notes
- Deadlines
- Progress tracking, including overdue flags, reminders and overdue prompts
- Task comments and a team updates thread
- Releasing a member's role and reopening it for a replacement
- Contribution tracking, including member review of the contribution summary
- Project completion and evidence

Should Have

- Full in-app chat
- Check-ins
- Notifications: inactivity notifications
- Guided reassignment of an inactive member's tasks
- Team health status
- Ranked matching with match explanations and closest partial matches
- Kick-off confirmation, adjustable team expectations and handover when a member leaves.
- Richer profile features, including optional portfolio links and additional profile customisation.
- Contribution notes, and credit rules for reassigned tasks and early exits
- Project page extras: screenshots, teammate-confirmation markers,

a personal view and closing a project as ended early

- Account controls: profile editing, account deletion and notification settings

Could Have

- Advanced compatibility scoring
- AI matching
- Portfolio analytics
- Mentor matching
- New owner nomination when the project owner is inactive

Could Have items come after the MVP and are not part of the six-week build, so they must not be planned into the sprints.

Items that are out of scope for the MVP are listed under Scope & Non-Scope.

Accountability in the MVP

Check-ins, inactivity detection and guided reassignment are Should Have, so the Must Have set carries the baseline: explicit commitment, clear roles, owners and deadlines, visible progress with overdue flags, reminders and overdue prompts, a way to release a role and find a replacement, and task comments with a team updates thread. The Should Have items add automated detection and guided recovery on top of that baseline.

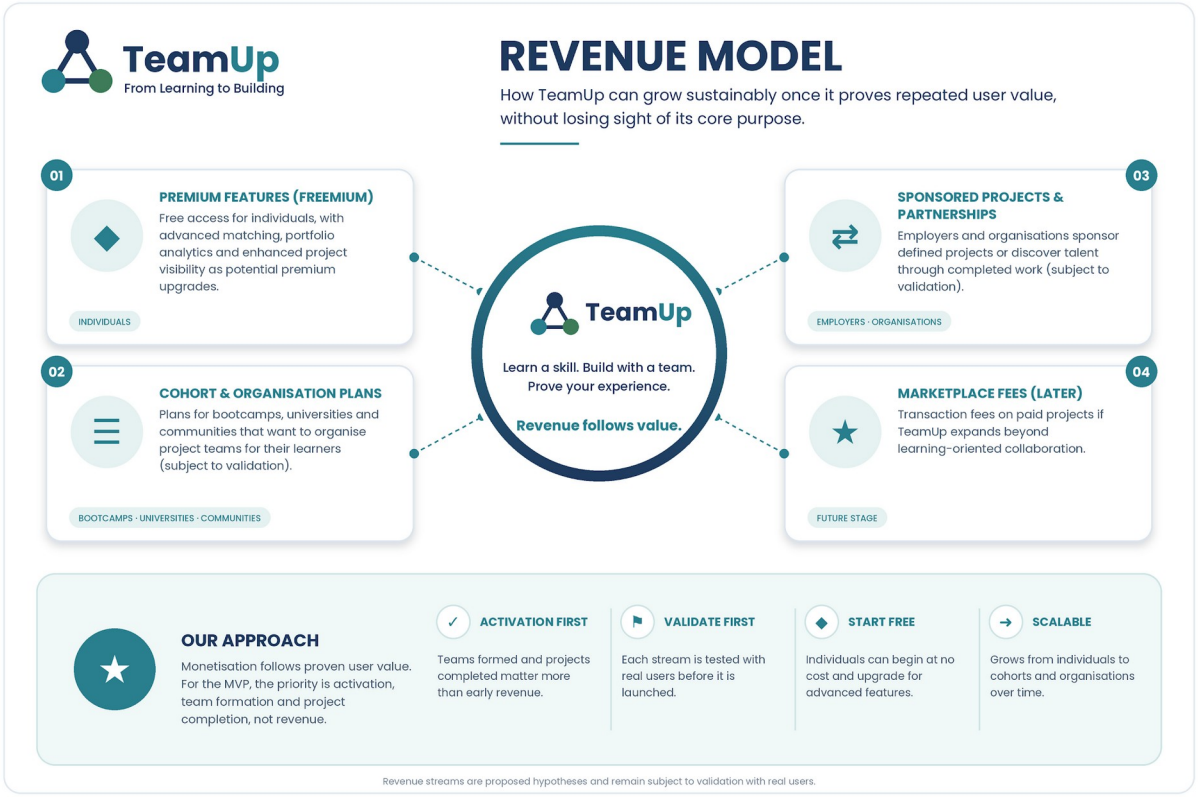
Success metrics

These metrics test whether TeamUp moves users from matching to successful completion, and they support the North Star: completed projects that produce real contribution evidence. The definitions are starting points. The first cohort sets the baseline, so no targets are set yet.

Metric	How it is measured (starting definition)
Team formation rate	Share of published projects that fill their required roles and reach kick-off.

Team activation rate	Share of formed teams that complete at least one task within seven days of kick-off.
First milestone completion	Share of teams that complete their first milestone by its target date.
Project completion rate	Share of started projects that reach Completed rather than Ended early or stalled.
Contribution-record completion	Share of members on completed projects whose contribution summary is confirmed.
Inactive-member recovery	Share of members flagged inactive who resume activity after follow-up or are replaced.
Repeat participation	Share of members who join or create a second project after completing one.

Revenue Model



TeamUp will initially prioritise user activation, team formation and project completion over revenue generation. Potential revenue streams include premium individual features, cohort and organisational plans, and sponsored projects or partnerships. Marketplace fees may be explored at a later stage if the platform expands to support paid projects. These are proposed revenue hypotheses, not confirmed revenue streams, and will be validated with users and potential partners before implementation.

Conclusion

TeamUp aims to bridge the gap between learning digital skills and gaining practical experience by helping users find collaborators, work on real projects and document their individual contributions.

The MVP focuses on the essential journey from discovering collaborators and forming committed teams to completing projects and generating portfolio evidence. By prioritising clear roles, accountability, task tracking and contribution records, TeamUp seeks to address common challenges that prevent collaborative projects from reaching completion.

The initial build will provide a foundation for testing the core experience with users. Feedback and success metrics from the first pilot will guide future improvements and help the team determine which additional features should be prioritised.

Ultimately, TeamUp’s success will be measured not simply by the number of users or teams formed, but by the number of projects completed and the meaningful evidence of experience users gain from them.